DRIFTMOOR

The Ballad of Isla's Shadow

Adventure Continuation Outline

Core weave

Kaelin's true memories of the rescue awaken Isla's lingering mark. The Pool of Echoes begins showing futures that have not happened, and Kalem sees a way to turn those futures into profit and power.

Designed as a flexible starting scaffold for a new group of player characters. The original adventurers remain in Driftmoor as witnesses, patrons, mentors, and people personally affected by the consequences of the first adventure.

Study notes

Questions, preferred choices, and player assignments:

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1. Core Premise

Kaelin regularly performs the story of the night the original adventurers rescued Isla. She embellishes the presentation, but not the important facts. These are her memories, and she knows what actually happened.

During one performance at the Broken Lantern, Kaelin reaches the moment when she cast Faerie Fire and revealed the shadowbeasts carrying the child. Isla, present with her family, begins tracing luminous symbols across the tabletop. Kaelin suddenly remembers something she has never remembered before: the same symbols appeared in the Pool of Echoes.

At that moment:

- Every flame in the tavern turns violet.
- Several listeners - the new player characters - briefly see Isla standing beside the Pool as an older child.
- In the vision, one of the Queen's chains lies broken.
- Kalem's representative leaves the tavern immediately.

> **Why the new characters become involved**
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> They are not selected by prophecy. They become involved because they witnessed the event, care about someone affected by it, react to the danger, or choose to follow the suspicious observer.

2. What Is Really Happening

The Queen marked Isla during the abduction, but the renewed binding prevents direct communication through the mark. The Pool of Echoes has begun functioning as a second route.

The Pool does not show one certain future. It reflects possible futures created by powerful memories and desires. Isla's mark is causing those possibilities to bleed into the present.

Kalem knows that objects exposed to the Pool can preserve visions as physical memories. He wants the marked child brought near the Pool - or, more plausibly, an impression of her mark - because he believes it can reveal intact obelisk fragments and hidden artifacts.

> **Kalem's moral position**
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> He is not necessarily trying to free the Queen. He is simply willing to risk weakening her prison for access to what the Pool knows.

3. Act I - A Song Remembered Wrong

Kaelin performs at the Broken Lantern, naturally bringing the previous adventure into the new players' experience. Partway through the song, she stops. A verse comes to her that she never wrote:

> *"The child bears the lock,*
> *the singer bears the key,*
> *and the pool remembers*
> *what never came to be."*

Kaelin is visibly shaken. She remembers the rescue clearly and insists the verse was not part of it. Isla draws three symbols: a broken chain, a rippling circle, and an eye or dark star beneath the water.

Real player options in the opening scene

- Examine or magically interpret the symbols.
- Comfort or protect Isla and support the Haversteads.
- Question Kaelin about the rescue and the limits of her memory.
- Follow Kalem's departing observer.
- Inspect the violet flames or search for an external magical source.
- Watch the crowd for anyone else reacting suspiciously.
- Prevent frightened townsfolk from turning against Isla.
- Refuse involvement but retain the unsettling shared vision.

> **Closing beat**
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> Isla speaks a phrase she should not know: "He put my memory in a box."

4. Act II - Three Competing Explanations

The investigation opens into three leads. The players may pursue them in any order, split their attention, or reject one source entirely.

Kaelin's memories

Kaelin can reconstruct the original adventure with them. Her memories are genuine, but one short interval near the Pool is missing. She remembers what happened before and afterward. She remembers terror and the certainty that someone watched from the trees, but not what she saw.

If Kaelin performs the melody she played after returning to Driftmoor, nearby characters glimpse fragments of the lost memory. Repeating it clarifies the vision while strengthening the connection to the Pool.

Isla's mark

The sigils appear only in response to particular stimuli:

- Kaelin's song
- Obelisk fragments
- Reflections in perfectly still water
- The sound of rattling metal
- Proximity to someone who has visited the Pool

Isla remains an innocent child, not a sinister oracle. Most of the danger comes from what adults want to do with her. The Haversteads refuse to permit another expedition to use their daughter. Earning their trust - or investigating without exposing Isla - becomes a central social challenge.

Kalem's interest

Kalem initially denies involvement. He claims he merely recognized the symbols and feared what they meant. He offers a bargain: bring him a harmless charcoal or wax impression of the mark, and he will provide:

- A vessel capable of holding a Pool vision
- A map to a safer route through Mistwood
- Information about someone who returned from the Pool with altered memories

> **The danger in the bargain**
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> The impression may give Kalem more access to Isla, the Pool, or the binding than he admits.

5. Act III - The Memory Box

Investigation reveals that the 'box' is a small artifact in Kalem's collection. He acquired it years ago from a frightened traveler. Its surface bears the same symbol Isla drew.

Opening it reveals a scene that has never happened:

- Isla, several years older, approaches the Pool voluntarily.
- Kaelin stands at the treeline, singing.
- One of the new adventurers is present.
- A chained figure speaks from beneath the reflection.
- Kalem reaches into the water and removes a dark, crown-shaped object.

The vision is a possibility, not a prediction. Its inclusion of a new character proves the Pool is updating its futures as events change.

Choices surrounding the Memory Box

- Steal the box from Kalem.
- Buy it or complete a favor in exchange.
- Force or persuade him to open it.
- Leave it sealed.
- Destroy it without viewing the complete memory.
- Use it to plant a false possibility in the Pool.
- Give it to Elyssa for study.
- Return it to the Pool and see what memory comes back.

6. Act IV - Return to the Pool

Something has changed in the Fey Glade:

- The ward still repels shadowbeasts, but pulses in time with Isla's mark.
- Flowers repeat fragments of Kaelin's melody when disturbed.
- Reflections show visitors arriving moments before they actually do.
- One person's reflection is absent.
- Kalem or one of his agents may already be there.

The Pool offers each character a personally compelling possible future. Accepting a vision grants useful information but costs a real memory until the Pool is dealt with.

Kaelin's vision

Kaelin sees herself celebrated for a heroic song that is almost true. In that future, she brought Isla back to the Pool to save Driftmoor. She cannot tell whether this is temptation, warning, or necessity.

7. The Central Decision

The party discovers that Isla's mark can serve one of three purposes:

A KEY	It could open a path through the Queen's binding.
A LOCK	Properly understood, it could reinforce the damaged prison.
A MAP	It records the relationship between the Queen, the Pool, and surviving obelisk fragments.

The mark has not yet committed to any one function. How people use it will determine what it becomes.

Final decision options

- Sever Isla's connection to the Pool, sacrificing its knowledge.
- Redirect the connection into the obelisk and strengthen the prison.
- Preserve the connection so Driftmoor can continue receiving visions.
- Let Kalem extract the information he wants in exchange for his expertise.
- Alter the mark by changing the memory around which it formed - Kaelin's memory of the rescue.

8. Kaelin's Role

Kaelin remains essential without becoming the DM-controlled protagonist. She functions as:

- The living connection to the previous adventure
- A trustworthy account of what actually happened
- The keeper of one crucial missing memory
- A performer whose music activates the supernatural mystery
- A moral witness when other NPCs begin treating Isla as an artifact
- A potential victim if the Pool starts rewriting the rescue story

> *"I change details to make a story sing. I do not change who was hurt, who was brave, or who came home. Something else is changing this one."*

9. Possible Endings

The mark is sealed

The party strengthens the prison. Isla is freed from the visions, but the Pool shows one final image of another marked child elsewhere.

The connection is preserved

Isla remains linked to the Pool under careful protection. Driftmoor gains warnings, but every vision subtly changes someone's memories.

Kalem gets what he wants

He helps save Isla and departs with the location of an intact network node, setting up the next expedition or a race to reach it first.

Kalem is outplayed

The party feeds the Memory Box a manufactured future. Kalem follows the false vision, but the Pool begins trying to make their invented story real.

Kaelin changes the song

Kaelin completes the missing verse with the new party's help. The shared story replaces the Queen's claim on Isla, but Kaelin can no longer remember one of the original adventurers.

10. Questions for Further Development

These choices can be settled after the new players and their assigned characters are known.

- Which original adventurers remain in Driftmoor, and what are they doing now?
- Which original character, if any, bears the Queen's mark or has Pool visions?
- What favor does Kalem believe the previous party owes him?
- Does Kalem want wealth, knowledge, influence, or a specific artifact?
- Who was the frightened traveler who originally sold the Memory Box?
- What personal future does the Pool show each new character?
- What real memory is each character unwilling to risk?
- How much do Mayor Aldren and Elyssa know about the Pool?
- What happens in Driftmoor if the players refuse to return to the glade?
- Which ending should remain possible but least obvious?

Next design step

Assign the new player characters. Their abilities, histories, and relationships can then be used to create distinct clues, risks, and real options in every act.

Working notes

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